

The 'A' Word

How we broke and fixed
team autonomy

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redgate



What we wanted

What we wanted

- Engaged, motivated teams

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- Teams feeling effective

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- Product Development fit to scale

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“We’re not getting the most out of our dev teams.”

“If we hire such great people, why are our results so mediocre?”

”I walk by and see people on Facebook, wtf”

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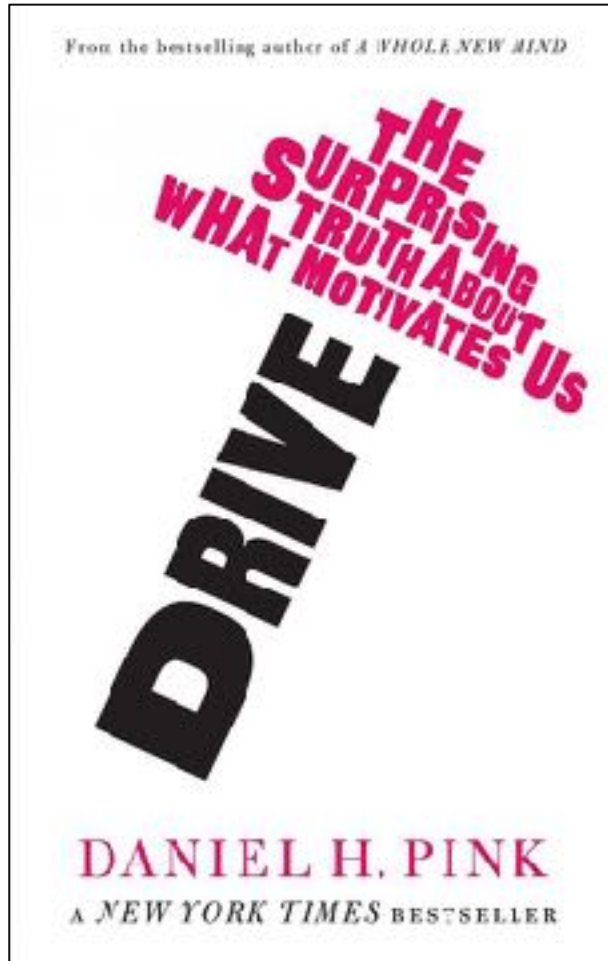
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Why “autonomous teams”?



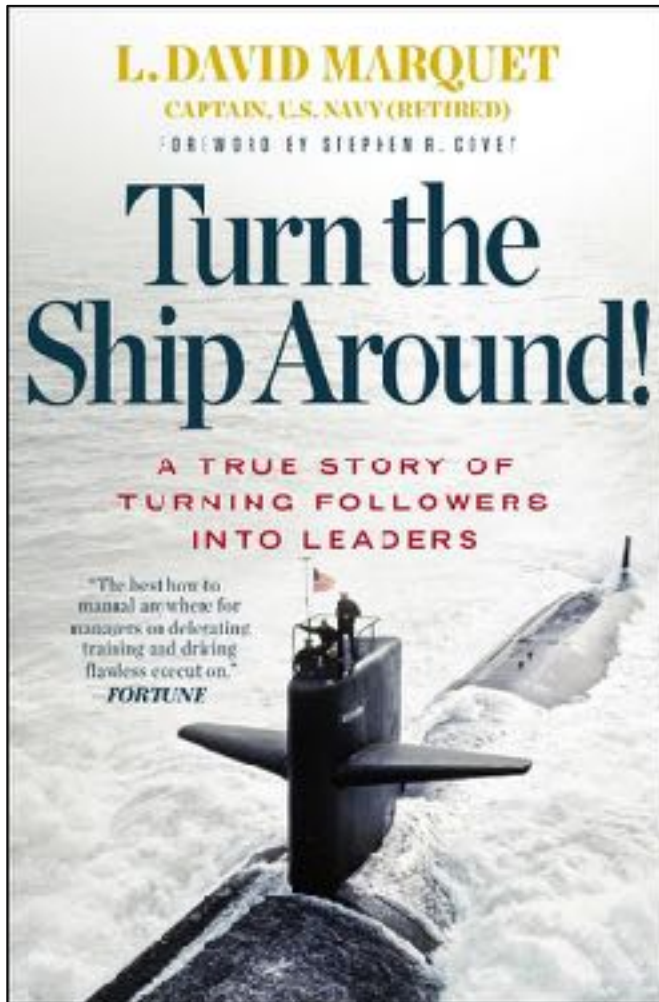


3 factors to increase employee satisfaction and performance

Autonomy

Mastery

Purpose



Giving control, not taking control
Pushing decisions to the
information
Leader-leader model



**We had the right conditions for
autonomous teams**

Our values

It's easy to get distracted from what really matters, so our values remind and guide us to do the right things for our users, our teams, and for Redgate.



We're reasonable

We treat everyone as we would want to be treated ourselves, even when the circumstances are difficult.



We're ingeniously simple

Our best products and services are ingeniously simple. The same goes for how we work internally. We work best when we don't overcomplicate things.



Transparency helps us continually improve

We make mistakes visible and share the evidence used to make decisions. No gossiping, no intrigue, no pussy-footing around problems.



We do our best work in teams

We continually improve when we make the most of everyone's expertise. The company is more important than the team and the team is more important than the individual.



When our customers succeed, so do we

Profits keep the score, but the game is to help customers succeed so they genuinely value what they pay for.



Don't be an asshole

No matter how smart you are, or how good you are at narrowly-defined tasks, there is no room for you here if you're an asshole.

Restructure

- Small teams:

- Technical Team Lead
- UX Designer
- 5 Software Engineers

- Coaching:

- Quality, Agile, Tech Comms

- Product Group Pairings:

- Development Leads & Product Managers



Chapter 1: "Autonomy"



Not this.



“

Redgate will give teams:

1. **Freedom to decide** how to engineer products to solve customer problems
 2. **Support** from specialists, coaches and experts in the organization
 3. **Clear direction** and constraints from technical & company strategy, allowing teams to align with a greater purpose or vision
 4. **Team stability**, aiming to keep teams together by default and move teams to the most important work, rather than breaking them up
- ”

“

We believe the following are key for teams building ingeniously simple software:

1. **Focus on your mission**

Everyone on the team should know their mission and how their current work contributes to it.



2. **Be transparent**

Everyone should be able to see your progress without having to ask what you're working on and why.

3. **Be agile**

Ship valuable software frequently and incrementally, get rapid feedback and be able to respond quickly.

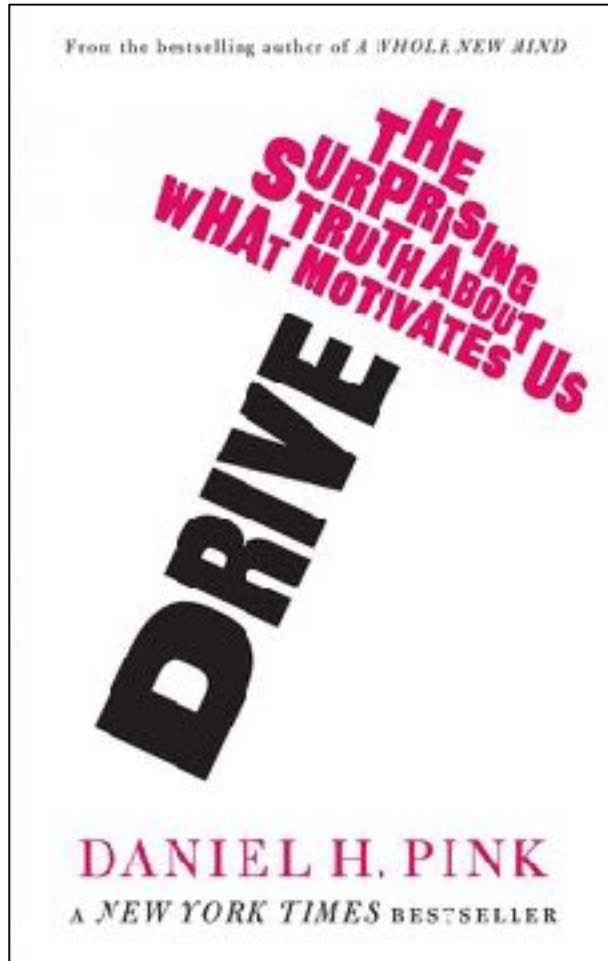
4. **Know your users, your product, your market**

The freedom to make critical decisions, comes with the

”



Clear expectations

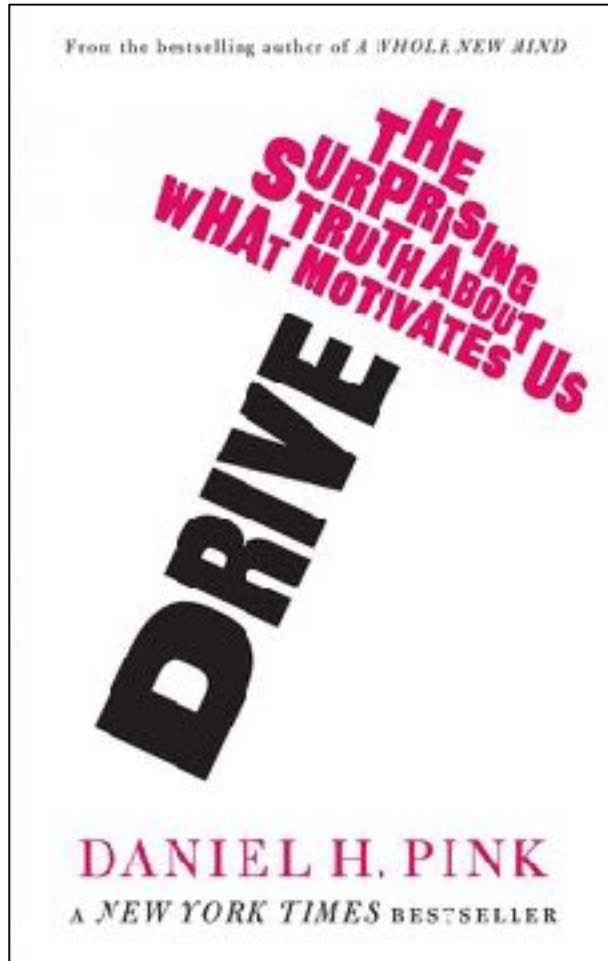


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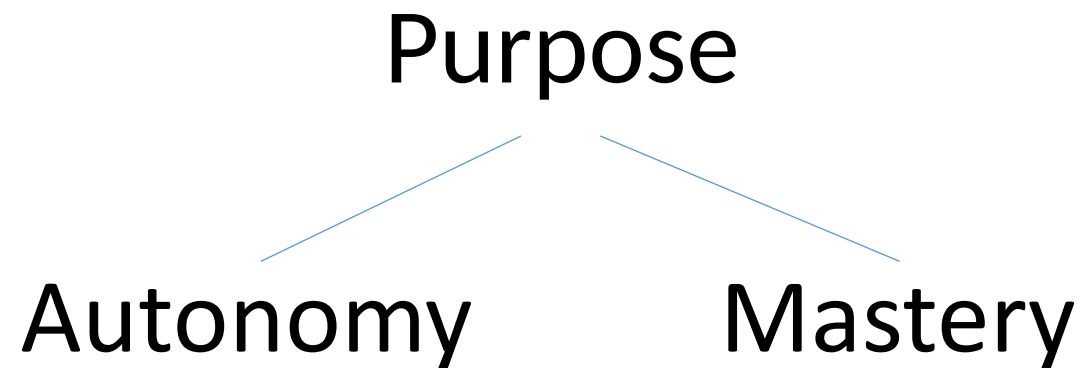
Autonomy

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3 factors to increase employee satisfaction and performance



https://www.ted.com/talks/simon_sinek_how_great_leaders_inspire_action#t-128122



14:48



What we're going to do to improve things

We think there are three distinct tasks that we need to tackle as soon as possible:

- Reframe autonomy and move away from using it as a mechanism for change – starting with this blog post and reinforced by the following steps.
- Clarify our vision for great engineering teams – this will look a little like this, building on themes we've already talked about since the restructure. I'd like to gather input from across the Product Division too (look out for more on this soon).
- Help teams assess where they are and agree what support they need to redo this too and then re-engage with the teams through

Sorry we made this confusing and thanks for letting us know about it but the proof of the pudding is in the eating - hopefully we'll all start



Chapter 2: The Capability Gap





OUR VISION FOR OUR TEAMS @ BEHANCE

Handwritten notes and numerous colorful sticky notes (pink, yellow, blue) covering the left whiteboard. The notes appear to be organized into sections, possibly related to team vision and goals.

EMERGENCY MAP
ERIC



Building a set of principles for our teams

FANTASTIC BEASTS

AND WHERE TO
IMPROVE THEM

Development teams at Redgate **enjoy** delivering **valuable**, **ingeniously simple** solutions with the help of six **Fantastic Beasts**



With the power of the **Porpoise** we stay focused on our **purpose**



The wise **Owl** focusses us on **learning** about our **users** and their world



The **transparency** of the **Jellyfish** keeps us open and **honest**



The **collaborative Meerkat** encourages us to **listen** and be mindful of others



The agile **Chameleon** reminds us to **adapt** as we frequently **inspect** feedback and learn from our situation



The proud **Koala** maintains a healthy balance between **delivery** and **quality**



redgate



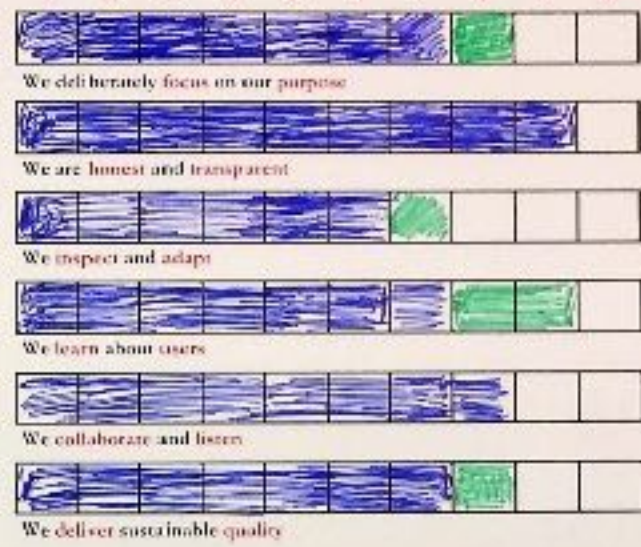
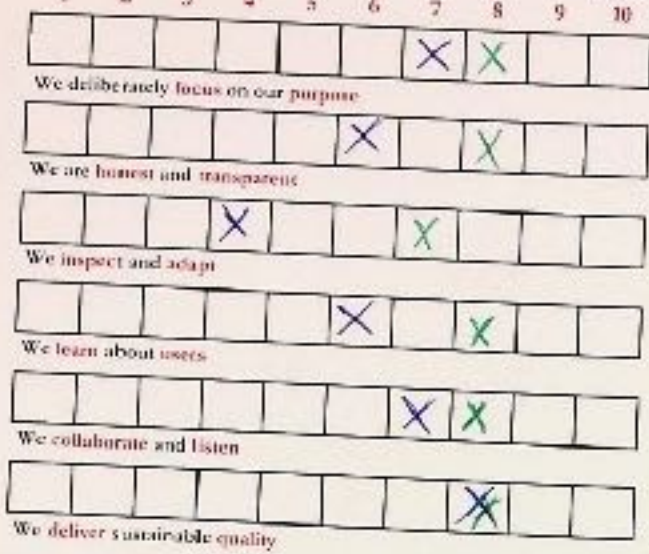
Owl

We learn about the users
of our products

Team members engage with our users and strive to learn about them and their world.

Team members understand the domain in which their products exists.

Teams use this knowledge to make critical decisions and build software that our customers love.



FANTASTIC BEASTS AND WHERE TO IMPROVE THEM



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How do we get closer to our users?





“Ohmygodohmygodohmygod... user calls!!!”

It's OK; we know agile. Right?





**The chasm
between a
product's
strategy and**

a backlog

Chapter 3: Developing Leaders



What leadership means to us



Attributes of a Redgate Leader*

1. Growing others
2. Courageous
3. Accountable and responsible
4. Encourage clarity
5. Value collaboration

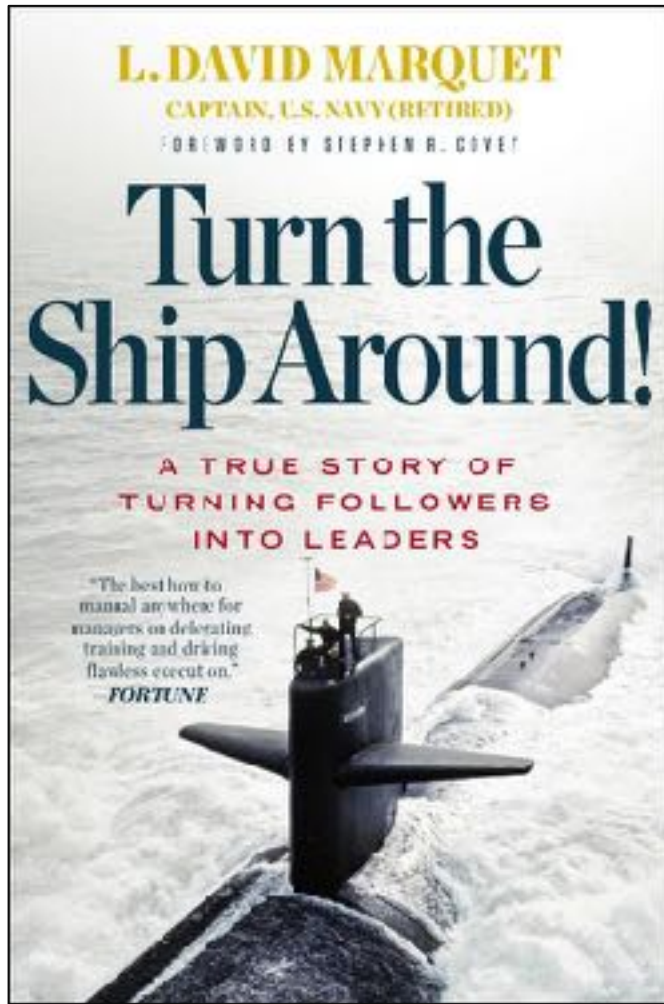
* These WILL be different for your org.



Tech Leads at 1 month



Tech Leads at 6 months



Giving control, not taking control

Pushing decisions to the information

Leader-leader model



Tech Leads at 6 months

Too much delegation to Tech Leads

AND

not enough delegation from them

Why not delegate?

Not appropriate to

Don't think about it

Everyone else is busy

Don't want to distract

Lack of skills

Not interested

Quicker for me to do it

Task is too important to delegate

Accountability is on me/losing control

Lack of knowledge/access

Don't know how

So they don't become the owner
in the future

Logical reasons

Task is super interesting

Dist. of opinion

Lack of trust they will do
it

Task is parts

Losing recognition

Delegating yourself out
of a job

Why we should delegate?

Good learning exercise

I like going home

Hit by the bus rule

Knowledge sharing

Shared ownership

Maintain balance of own role

Other people can do it better

Helping team performance

Motivating and helps develop skills

Builds trust

Encourages reliance - sense of team

TO AVOID LEARNT HELPLESSNESS
FROM TEAM

Giving people chance of
different roles

Different view of task

It is a skill

Don't have time

Proving valid task

TO LOOK AFTER
YOURSELF

↳ SO YOU ARE
IN A BETTER PLACE
TO HELP THE TEAM

Where is Redgate now?



Moved the needle on

Moved the needle on

- More engaged and motivated teams

Moved the needle on

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- Teams feeling effective for the business

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Inertia



Lessons

1. 'Autonomy' is an explosive word
2. Don't introduce extra tension. Orgs have enough.
3. Align on Purpose. Autonomy and Mastery must support 'why'.



Lessons

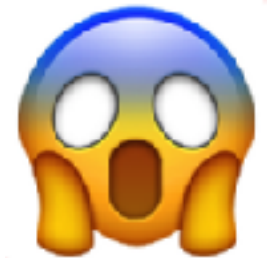
4. Engage teams in their own improvement.



5. Capability assessment needs both team and manager.



6. Leaders need to grow leaders who grow leaders.



End model

Business and Product Strategy 'as normal'

Dev teams take on parts of the PO role

- Managing their own backlog
- Sprint goals

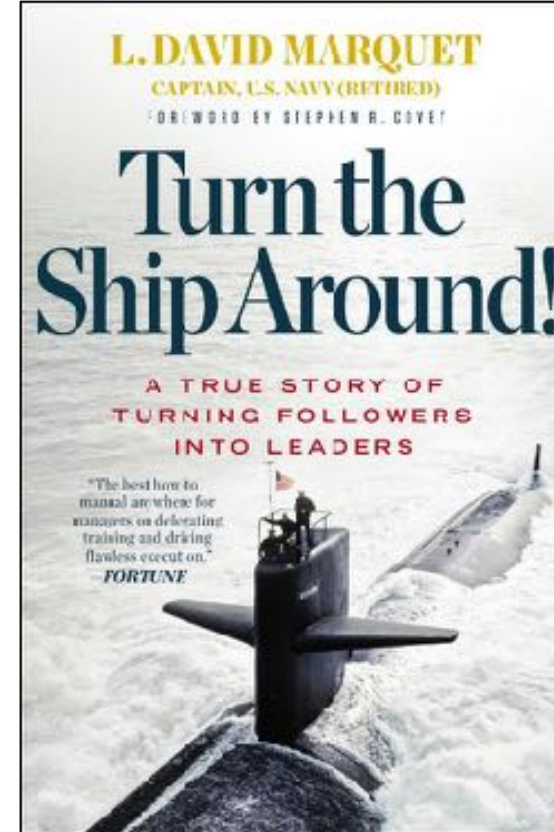
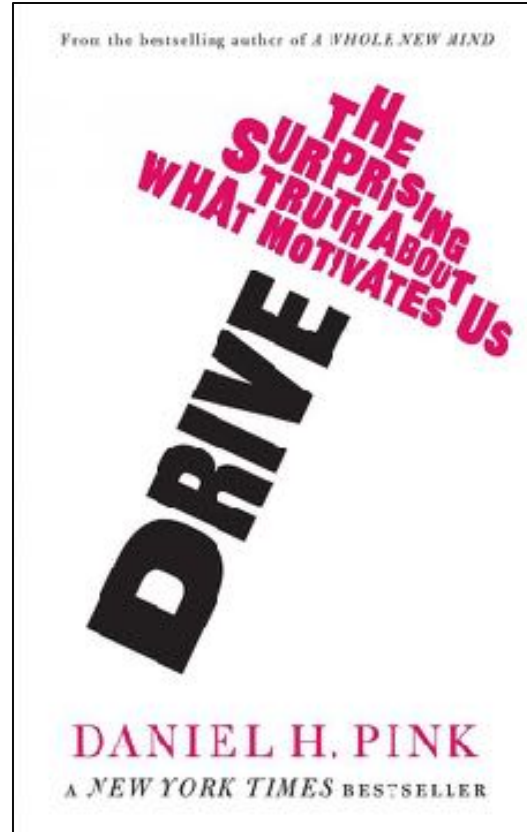
Dev hooks up with business via mutually agreed OKRs (mostly Os)

Dev teams drive improvements in their own effectiveness

- Dev managers supply perspective and education options

Management creates an environment for teams to thrive by setting general direction and giving support.

Resources



Resources

- The Spotify Model
 - <https://medium.com/the-ready/how-to-build-your-own-spotify-model-dce98025d32f>
- Start with Why
 - <https://startwithwhy.com/>
- Fantastic Beasts
 - https://www.slideshare.net/chris_smith1976/fantastic-beasts-and-where-to-improve-them-agile-cambridge-29th-september-2017
- Involving dev teams in user research
 - <https://www.slideshare.net/ElizabethAyer/aitc2018-ux-impact-elizabeth-ayer>
- Delegation
 - <https://medium.com/ingeniouslysimple/how-to-get-more-done-by-doing-less-f047d2f53d47>

A low-angle shot of a red roller coaster track curving upwards and then over a hill, set against a bright blue sky with scattered white clouds. The track is made of metal and has a series of supports.

Questions?